

The past perfect

Teaching guide

Show what had happened before another past point.

Understand the distinction

Form the past perfect with had + past participle: had left, had seen, had finished. It looks back from a past reference point to an earlier event or state.

Use it when the order or earlier background matters. It is not required for every earlier event if before, after, or context already makes the sequence clear. The negative is had not + participle; a question begins with Had + subject.

Compare the patterns

EARLIER EVENT

The train had left when I arrived.

The departure happened before the arrival.

EARLIER STATE

I had never visited before that trip.

Look back from the time of the trip.

QUESTION

Had you booked before you called?

Had comes before the subject.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: She had ___ before I arrived. (leave)

A. leaving

B. left

C. leave

2. What happened first: I had eaten when the guests arrived?

A. The guests arrived first.

B. I ate first.

C. The two actions necessarily started together.

3. Is past perfect always required after after?

A. No. Past perfect can never be used with after.

B. No. After can already make the order clear.

C. Yes. After always requires had.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. The shop closed before you arrived. Which sentence makes that order clear?

- A. The shop closed after I reached it.
- B. When I reached the shop, it had already closed.
- C. When I reached the shop, it would close tomorrow.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. left

Use the past participle after had.

A: Had leaving is not the past perfect form of leave.

C: Had takes the past participle left in this pattern.

2. B. I ate first.

Had eaten places the meal before the arrival.

A: Had eaten places the eating before their arrival.

C: Past perfect places the eating earlier; it does not mean simultaneous starts.

3. B. No. After can already make the order clear.

After I finished, I left is natural.

A: Past perfect is possible when emphasizing an earlier completed action.

C: After can make the sequence clear even with past-simple verbs.

4. B. When I reached the shop, it had already closed.

Had already closed places the closure before the arrival.

A: After reverses the stated order.

C: This places the closure in the future instead.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-26.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

The shop closed before you arrived. Which sentence makes that order clear?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.